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## Micro Finance

Micro finance, also known as micro credit, is a financial service that offers loans, savings and insurance to entrepreneurs and small business owners who do not have access to traditional sources of capital, like banks or investors. The goal of micro financing is to provide individuals with money to invest in themselves or their business. Microfinance is available through micro finance institutions, which range from small nonprofit organizations to larger banks. In India, Non Government Organizations (NGOs) play a pivotal role in the development of micro finance service. Microfinance industry in India have grown vastly in the last two decades. In 2009, the total number of micro finance institutions in India was around 150 (Tripathi, 2014).

## Self-Help Groups (SHGs)

Self Help Groups are informal voluntary association of poor people, from the similar socio-economic background, up to 20 women (average size is 14). They come together for the purpose of solving their common problems through self-help and mutual help. The SHG promotes small savings among its members. They save small amounts Rs.10 to Rs.50 a month. The savings are kept with a bank. After saving regularly for a minimum of 6 months, they lend small amounts to their members for interest. Based on their performance, they are linked with the bank for further assistance under SHG Bank Linked Programme (SBLP) started in 1992. It is a holistic programme of micro-enterprises covering all aspects of self-employment, organization of the rural poor into self Help groups and their capacity building, planning of activity clusters, infrastructure build up, technology, credit and marketing.

The main objective of this programme is to bring the beneficiaries above the poverty line by providing income generating assets to them through bank credit and government subsidy. NABARD estimates

In 2009-10, the number of new SHGs having credit-linked with banks was 1.59 million and a bank loan of Rs.14,453 Crores was disbursed to these SHGs. Further, the number of SHGs which maintained savings accounts with banks at the end of March 2010 was 6.95 million.

Under NABARD SHG Linkage Programme, SHGs can borrow credit from bank on showing their successful track record of regular repayments of their borrowers. It has been successful in the states like Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Karnataka during 2005-06. These States received approximately 60 per cent of SHG linkage credit (Taruna and Yadav, 2016).